

5, The War to Resist US Aggression and Aid Korea Could Not Halt the Grand Trend of the Oikumene

For me personally, re-evaluating World War II has also been a profoundly meaningful endeavor. I now realize that since the modern era (*here, "modern" refers to the general sense of humanity collectively entering the industrial society*), nine times out of ten, the ultimate success or failure of a nation is not decided on the battlefield. Rather, **the victor and the vanquished have already been predetermined; war is merely the medium through which the final outcome manifests.**

The disparities in the societal stages occupied by various nations are so massive, and social transformations since the modern era have occurred so rapidly, that this generational gap (代差)—born from fundamental advancements or backwardness in social structure—can no longer be compensated for by population scale, brilliant strategy, the genius of a few leaders, or even sheer luck bestowed by heaven.

The year 2023 marked the 70th anniversary of the victory of what China calls the "War to Resist US Aggression and Aid Korea" (抗美援朝战争). Although the armistice agreement was ultimately signed in the second half of the year, official propaganda surged massively starting in the first half.

Consequently, I took some time to reconsider the historical event of the Korean War.

Our official narrative claims that the Korean War itself ultimately ended in a draw, because the final ceasefire line was not far from the original 38th Parallel. Compared to the beginning of the war, South Korea gained more territory in the eastern sector, while North Korea acquired the ancient capital of Kaesong (开城).

As for the Chinese "War to Resist US Aggression and Aid Korea," it is portrayed as a victory because China did not initiate the Korean War, nor did the People's Volunteer Army (PVA / 志愿军) enter Korea right at the beginning. (*Before the war, ethnic Korean troops from the Fourth Field Army during the Chinese Civil War were indeed transferred to North Korea, but these troops participated at the outbreak of the war strictly as North Korean armed forces, not as the Chinese military*).

Up to this point, there is no major flaw in our country's official propaganda. However, the subsequent point easily provokes deep reflection: **Chinese officialdom incessantly propagandizes that "the Chinese People's Volunteer Army repelled the interference in Korea by the United Nations Command (联合国军) led by the United States."**

They heavily emphasize that the "UN Command" comprised over a dozen countries, including traditional imperial powers like Britain, France, and the US. They then contrast this with the "impoverished and weak" (积贫积弱) image of the late Qing government and the Republic of China, which were repeatedly invaded decades prior, to illustrate that **"the Chinese people have stood up"** (中国人民从此站起来了).

However, following this logic, a moment's reflection reveals a crucial, counter-intuitive reality.

It is indeed a fact that the Chinese People's Volunteer Army and the Korean People's Army, bolstered by Soviet aid, repelled the UN Command as it approached the Yalu River.

But does the US-led "United Nations Command" have any precedent in history? Has there ever been another country in the past capable of organizing a massive allied force under the banner of "United Nations" to defend the independence of a regime?

The answer is glaringly obvious. Regardless of the extent to which the Americans might have twisted the UN resolution to place the coalition forces under their own control, the very fact that this million-man army could be organized, effectively commanded, deployed in high-intensity warfare for three years (*certainly high-intensity considering the overall post-WWII situation*), and ultimately succeed in preserving South Korea, **inherently manifested and cemented America's global leadership capability!**

If we look at this from the perspective of Joseph Stalin, the primary instigator of the Korean War, the colossal role played by the "UN Command" becomes incredibly easy to see.

As mentioned in the previous paragraph, although people habitually refer to the confrontation between the blocs led by the US and the USSR in the decades following WWII as the "Cold War," **these two blocs were fundamentally not on equal footing from any perspective.**

The notion that "the Soviet Union was sufficient to rival the United States" is, ultimately, a product of people's ideological conceptions rather than reality.

The reason lies in the fact that the United States genuinely created a world order that universally benefited participating nations. Even neutral countries that ostensibly did not belong to the US-Soviet blocs were, in reality, integrated into the US-led international order.

Conversely, not only did the Soviet Union have no desire to lead an international order of its own, but it fundamentally lacked the capability to do so even if it wanted to! It was already a massive blessing if the Soviet Union could manage to orchestrate an incredibly crude division of labor within its own bloc, rather than rushing to overtly plunder the territory, resources, and technology of its satellite states (仆从国).

In fact, even the Soviet Union itself was forced to hover on the periphery of the US-led world order! It still desperately required certain technological transfers from developed Western nations, not to mention the necessity of exporting massive amounts of energy to the international market rather than merely within the Soviet bloc.

Therefore, we can say that although the United States is nominally just a single country, it effectively reaps the benefits of an (almost equivalent to) global market encompassing trade, investment, labor, and talent. This was an unimaginable advantage for the Soviet bloc, which had set up a separate enclave on the "periphery of the world." Under this dynamic of one side rising while the other wanes (此消彼长之下), the ultimate defeat of the Soviet Union was entirely predictable.

Consequently, if Stalin realized this problem in his twilight years, knowing he could not win, the maximal objective he could pursue was a **"lose-lose"** (双输) outcome—that is, to preemptively sabotage the immature world order the US had just established.

Judging from the actions he took, one has every reason to believe that Stalin, as an exceedingly cunning and treacherous dictator (老奸巨猾的独裁者), was capable of perceiving this grand historical trend.

He first provoked the **Berlin Crisis** in 1948 to probe America's capability and willingness to defend the security of its allies. However, the United States responded powerfully through the Berlin Airlift.

In the year following the end of the first Berlin Crisis, Stalin instigated Kim Il-sung to drive south and attack South Korea as another military probe. But when the US once again demonstrated a hardline stance to resolutely defend its allies and shared values, Stalin himself recoiled. The Soviet representative outright boycotted the UN meeting, thereby enabling the US to organize the so-called "UN Command" exactly according to its own will.

To avoid the total loss of the Korean Peninsula buffer zone, the Soviets had no choice but to rely on the Chinese to deploy troops while they merely provided indirect military support. Yet, even so, the independence of South Korea was ultimately preserved.

Therefore, one can assert that the nature of the Korean War was fundamentally identical to the Berlin Crisis: **it was an offensive that the Soviet bloc *had to win***. It was absolutely not a scenario where merely holding onto pre-war territory could be declared a victory.

When the Americans repeatedly demonstrated their resolution and capability to defend their own values and the shared interests of their allies in the face of aggressive Soviet offensives, the US-led international order became increasingly consolidated, and other nations developed profound trust in the US. The Soviet-aligned nations, on the other hand, could only become increasingly isolated, left entirely behind by the tide of the world. Defeat was inevitable.

The fact is, in the late 1940s and early 1950s, it was impossible for the Soviets to destroy the newborn international order using any non-military means. And neither the Chinese, the North Koreans, nor any allies the Soviets could utilize possessed the capability to shatter the US-led world order through war.

The Soviet Union's only remaining option was to launch a direct war against the US themselves—to fight another World War. As long as more than half the world was turned back into ruins, what meaning would it hold even if the Americans ruled over a massive pile of rubble?

However, whether due to the catastrophic losses the Soviet Union suffered in the war against Germany, or Stalin's personal attitude of "understanding the times" (识时务), Russia ultimately did not act as fanatical leftists like Trotsky had hoped: *"setting themselves on fire to destroy the imperialist order."*

When the communist bloc's several sabotage operations at the dawn of the Cold War all ended in failure, then as far as the Cold War was concerned, the "**Battle of Sekigahara**" (关原合战) had already been fought and concluded. As for when the "**Siege of Osaka**" (大坂之阵) would be fought, it was purely a matter of time—not to mention that the eventual disintegration of the Soviet Union was primarily due to its own internal rot.

Therefore, the Korean War can absolutely not be considered a draw; it was a monumental victory achieved by the United States. For the US, the new leader of the world, the Korean War was undoubtedly a milestone on its path to pacifying the realm (平定天下).

As for the strategic buffer zone that the Chinese believe the *War to Resist US Aggression and Aid Korea* preserved for them, it can hardly be counted as any real achievement. **When the grand tide**

of history has irreversibly swept past, how can the gain or loss of a tiny corner of Korea compare to the gain or loss of the entire world?! (大势去矣，朝鲜一隅之地岂能比天下之得失哉！)

During Toyotomi Hideyoshi's unification of Japan, the Shimazu clan also massively routed the supreme ruler's punitive army at the Battle of Hetsugigawa (户次川). Yet, this neither shook the Toyotomi public regime nor could it possibly halt the overarching tide of Japan's unification.

Claiming victory merely because North Korea was preserved carries a heavy flavor of "**shooting the arrow first and drawing the bullseye later**" (先射箭后画靶子). Did the Chinese initially not hope to annihilate South Korea? Impossible! Otherwise, why did they attempt to continue advancing southward after capturing Seoul? Were they going on a sightseeing tour?

If one spends any amount of time living in China, it is incredibly easy to understand: even if the Korean War had ultimately ended with South Korea unifying the peninsula, our country's propaganda would *still* claim the *War to Resist US Aggression and Aid Korea* was a magnificent victory—because they would just say that if we hadn't deployed troops, even Manchuria (the three northeastern provinces) couldn't have been saved!

When you shoot the arrow first and then draw the bullseye around where it lands, it is impossible to lose. Even if you shoot the arrow directly into your own foot, you simply draw a bullseye on your foot and declare victory!

The so-called *War to Resist US Aggression and Aid Korea* was a war where the Chinese people were shackled to a train hurtling toward a cliff, solely due to the ambitions of the Soviet rulers. At the cost of catastrophic sacrifices in human lives and material resources, China achieved nothing more than tactical victories while ultimately suffering a massive strategic defeat.

For the people of our country, this is an excruciating tragedy too unbearable to look back upon. Feeling "pride and glory" for this war is truly, utterly absurd.

5, 抗美援朝战争无法阻挡天下大势

对我个人而言，重新理解二战也是一件颇有意义的事，我现在感到自近代以来（这里说的近代就是一般意义上的说法，人类整体上进入工业社会）天下成败十之八九不在战场之上决定，而是胜负已分的情况下，才最终通过战争体现出来罢了。各国所处的社会阶段差异如此之大，而近代以来社会变革产生的又如此之快，这种基于社会结构上本质上的先进与落后所形成的代差，再也不是人口规模，杰出的战略，少数领袖的天才甚至是上天给予的运气所能弥补的。23 年是中国所谓的抗美援朝战争胜利 70 周年，虽然最终停战协定是在下半年签订的，但是从今年上半年开始官方的宣传就变得很多了。于是我也抽空重新考虑了一下朝鲜战争这个历史事件，我们官方的说法是，朝鲜战争最终是平局，因为停火线本身离三八线不远，比起开战之初来看韩国在东段获得的领土更多，但是朝鲜获得了古都开城。对于中国人的抗美援朝战争来说则是取胜了的，因为不是中国主动挑起的朝鲜战争，志愿军也不是一开始就进入了朝鲜（在战前确实有将解放战争期间的第四野战中朝鲜族军队转交给朝鲜方面的情况，但是这些军队在朝鲜战争之初就是以朝鲜武装力量的身份参与的战争，而不是以中国军队的身份）。到这里我国官方宣传其实没有什么大的问题，但是接下来的一点就很容易引起人的深思了，那就是中国官方总是宣扬“中国人民志愿军击退了以美国为首的联合国军对朝鲜的干涉”，非常强调“联合国军”包含十几个国家并且含有英法美这样的传统列强，并与几十年前晚清政府和中华民国屡遭侵略，“积贫积弱”的形象做对比，以说明“中国人民从此站起来了”。

然而如此一来人们稍加思索就会意识到一个重要的反面事实，中国人民志愿军和朝鲜人民军在苏联援助下击退了逼近鸭绿江的联合国军确实是事实，但是美国所领导的“联合国军”，这在历史上难道有先例吗？过去难道有其他国家以“联合国”的名义组织一众盟军去保卫一个政权的独立吗？回答是很明显的，无论美国人在何种程度上曲解了联合国的决议，将联军置于自己的控制之下，但是这支百万大

军能被组织起来，有效地指挥，参与了长达三年的高强度战争（当然是对二战以后的总体形势来看），最终确实也保住了韩国，这本身就彰显并巩固了美国的全球领导能力。如果我们站在朝鲜战争的最主要教唆者斯大林的角度来看，就会很容易看到“联合国军”所发挥的巨大作用。就如上一段所说，虽然人们习惯上把二战结束之后几十年间以美苏两国为首的阵营对峙称为冷战，但是这两个阵营在哪个角度讲都根本不是对等的，“苏联足以和美国对抗”终究是人们观念中的产物而并非事实。原因在于，美国真正创造了一个使得参与国家普遍受益的世界秩序，即使表面上不属于美苏阵营的中立国家，它在事实上也被纳入了以美国为首的国际秩序中。而苏联不要说想不想去主导一个自己的国际秩序，它在事实上也没有能力完成这一点，苏联能在本阵营内部极其粗糙地完成社会分工，而不是急于掠夺仆从国的领土、资源和技术就已经善莫大焉了。甚至于苏联自己也不得不游离在美国主导的世界秩序边缘，因为它自己还需要来自西方发达国家的一定技术转移，更别说在国际市场而非苏联阵营内出口大量的能源。

所以说美国表面上虽然只是一个国家，但却能享有一个（几乎等同于）全球市场所带来的贸易、投资、劳动力、人才等各方面的收益，这是在“世界边缘”另立门户的苏联阵营所不可想象的优势，此消彼长之下，苏联的最终失败是完全可以预知的。因此如果斯大林在晚年意识到这个问题，他在自己赢不了的情况下所能追求的最大目标无非是双输，也就是趁早破坏美国刚刚建立的还不成熟的世界秩序。从他所采取的行动来看，人们有理由相信斯大林作为一个老奸巨猾的独裁者是能够看到这种历史大势的。他先是在 1948 年挑起柏林危机，以此窥测美国捍卫盟友安全的能力和意愿，但是美国通过柏林空运给予了有力回应。在第一次柏林危机结束的次年，斯大林又唆使金日成南下进攻韩国以进行军事上的试探，但是当美国再一次展现了坚定捍卫盟国及共同价值观的强硬姿态之后，斯大林本人退缩了，苏联代表干脆缺席了会议，使得美国可以按自己的意愿组织所谓的联合国军。为了避免朝鲜半岛的缓冲区完全丧失，苏联人不得不依靠中国人出兵而自己提供间接的军事支持，可即便如此韩国的独立最终得到了维护。因此人们可以说，朝鲜战争的性质本质上和柏林危机一样，是苏联阵营不得不取胜的一次攻势，这绝不是保住了开战之前的领土就可以宣布胜利的。当美国人在面对苏联咄咄逼人的攻势时一次又一次地展现了自己维护自身价值观和与盟友共同利益的决心和能力，美国所主导的国际秩序就会越来越稳固，其他国家也会形成对美国的信赖。而苏联一方的国家就只能愈发孤立，被远远地甩在世界潮流之后，失败是不可避免的事情。

事实就是，在 40 年代末 50 年代初的时候，苏联人使用任何非军事手段都不可能破坏新生的国际秩序，而中国人、朝鲜人或者任何苏联人可以利用的盟国也没有通过战争破坏美国主导的世界秩序的能力，苏联唯一的办法就是自己发动与美国的战争，再打一次世界大战。只要让大半个世界重新变成废墟，那么美国人即使统治了一大堆废墟又有什么意义呢？但是无论是苏联经过与德国战争的巨大损失也好，斯大林本人“识时务”的态度也罢，俄国终究没有像托洛茨基这样的狂热左派所希望的一样“燃烧自己以摧毁帝国主义秩序”。当冷战之初共产主义阵营的数次破坏行动均以失败告终的时候，那么对冷战来说“关原合战”就已经打完了，至于什么时候打“大坂之阵”完全是一个时间问题，更何况苏联方面的瓦解主要还是其内部问题。因此朝鲜战争就绝对不能算什么平局，而是美国取得的重大胜利，对于美国这个新的世界领袖来说，朝鲜战争无疑是其平定天下道路上的里程碑。至于中国人认为的抗美援朝为自己保留的战略缓冲区也实在难算什么成绩，大势去矣，朝鲜一隅之地岂能比天下之得失哉！在丰臣秀吉统一日本的过程中，岛津家也曾在户次川大破天下人的讨伐军，可是这既不能动摇丰臣公仪政权，更不可能阻挡日本统一的大势。声称自己保住了北朝鲜就是胜利多少有点先射箭后画靶子的意味，难道中国人最开始不希望消灭韩国吗？怎么可能！要不然攻下汉城后还试着继续南进是去旅游不成。如果一个人在中国待上一段时间就很容易理解，就算朝鲜战争最后以南朝鲜统一半岛告终，那么我国的宣传仍然会说抗美援朝是一场伟大胜利，因为如果不出兵连东三省都保不住了。当你先把箭射出去再在落点画靶子的时候这就是不可能输的，就算你把箭射到脚底下，那么无非是在脚底下画上靶子，然后宣布胜利罢了。所谓抗美援朝战争，就是一场中国人民因为苏联统治者的野心而被绑上一辆冲向悬崖的列车，以极大的人力和物力的牺牲，仅仅取得了战术胜利，在战略上最终失败的战争。这对我国人民而言是一件不堪回首的惨事，为这场战争感到骄傲和自豪实在是过于莫名其妙了。